

Royal Letter of Joan I to an Unnamed Bishop concerning 400 Florins

ACA, Cancillería — Barchinona, 7 June 1387

Document Summary

Field	Value
Archival reference	ACA, Cancillería [register/folio not legible in image; cited folio f. 121r]
Date	7 June 1387 (<i>a VII dies de juny, l'any de M CCC LXXX VII</i>)
Place of issue	Barchinona (Barcelona)
Language	Catalan
Document type	Royal letter / payment mandate (<i>letra</i> with <i>iussio</i>)
Issuing authority	Joan I of Aragon (<i>Lo Rey</i>)
Subscription	Francesch ça Cost[a] (vice-chancellor)
Addressee	An unnamed bishop (<i>Honrat pare en Jesuchristu</i>)
Bearer / payee	Jacme Sala, bearer of the letter, with <i>ple poder</i> to receive the sum
Third party	Johan de Muntros
Subject	Order to pay 400 florins, the outstanding remainder of a 1,000-florin sum previously granted to the king at Barcelona, to the bearer Jacme Sala against an <i>àpoca</i> and the return of the original obligation; the king notes that the realm's other bishops have been assessed comparable sums.

Reconciled Transcription

| Lo Rey.

Honrat pare en Jesuchristu, per haver aquelles CCCC florins restants a pagar d'aquells Mil florins que [l'altre dia / tals dies?]¹ estants en la Ciutat de Barchinona per provehir [?]² [a] nostres grans necessitats propiament [?] nos atorgàs, trametem a vos lo feel portador d'aquesta, en Jacme Sala, ab ple[u?]³ poder de rebre aquells. Ab una obligació que M. DC. florins⁴ que ja havets pagats en Johan de Muntros, dels dits Mil florins, fets al dit Johan de Muntros, la qual a major cautela vostra volem que·us sia dada en sa forma. Per què·us pregam que, vista la present, lliurets o lliurar façats al dit portador los dits CCCC florins, ell fahent a vos àpoca⁵ d'aquells e restituint vos la dita obligació. Certificants vos que cascun dels altres bisbes de nostra senyoria⁶ per la dita rahó nos han de M florins per semblant forma propiament atorgats. Dada en Barchinona a VII dies de juny l'any de M CCC LXXX VII.⁷ — Francesch ça Cost[a].⁸

Annotated English Translation

The King.^a

Honored father in Jesus Christ,^b concerning those 400 florins remaining to be paid out of those 1,000 florins which — [the other day / on certain days?]¹ when we were in the City of Barcelona, in order to provide for² our great necessities — you granted to us in person:^c we send to you the faithful bearer of this letter, en^d Jacme Sala, with full power³ to receive them. With respect to an obligation of 1,600 florins⁴ which you have already paid to en Johan de Muntros, of the said 1,000 florins, make [it] out to the said Johan de Muntros — which [obligation], for your greater security, we wish to be given to you in its [proper] form. Wherefore we ask you that, the present [letter] having been seen, you deliver, or cause to be delivered, to the said bearer the said 400 florins — he making out to you a receipt⁵ for them and restoring to you the said obligation. We certify to you that each of the other bishops of our lordship⁶ have, for the said reason, granted us 1,000 florins each in person in like form. Given at Barcelona on the 7th day of June in the year 1387.⁷ — Francesc ça Cost[a].⁸

Footnotes

a. Lo Rey. The bare royal intitulation at the head of the letter, in the king's own "voice," is characteristic of the *letra* form (as opposed to the solemn *littera patens* with full titulature). The document is a directive missive, not a privilege.

b. Honrat pare en Jesuchristu. The salutation form reserved for a bishop. The addressee is not named in the legible portion of the text, which is itself notable: the letter belongs to a series sent to multiple prelates (see note 6), and the chancery may have left the addressee to be supplied per copy, or named him in a portion not captured here.

c. The syntax of the opening period is elliptical and the antecedents are compressed. The sense is: of a 1,000-florin sum that the bishop had personally granted (*nos atorgàs*) to the king during a stay in Barcelona, 400 remain outstanding; the present letter authorizes the bearer to collect that balance. *Propiament* ("in person, personally" / "properly") qualifies the manner of the original grant. Translation here follows the king's first-person plural (*havem, trametem, volem, pregam*) throughout.

d. *en* — the Catalan honorific particle preceding a man's name ($\approx$ "Sir / Master"), retained untranslated.

1. The temporal/circumstantial phrase governing *estants en la Ciutat de Barchinona* is unresolved. The HTR comparator read *l'altre dia* ("the other day"); the manuscript shows a compressed cluster that may instead be *tals dies* or similar. The reading affects only the precise dating of the original grant, not its substance. Flagged for verification against the register.

2. *provehir* vs *supplicar*. The verb governing *nostres grans necessitats* is paleographically ambiguous. *Provehir* [*a*] *nostres grans necessitats* ("to provide for our great needs") is idiomatic and adopted here; the HTR's *supplicar* ("to supplicate") does not yield good sense with *necessitats* as object. Retained as a flagged crux because the paleographic distinction is not decisive.

3. *ple poder* (full power; *plena potestas*) — the standard formula authorizing the bearer to act as the king's procurator in receiving the sum. The image shows a form the HTR rendered *pleu*; *ple* is expected on formulaic grounds. Minor, flagged.

4. The florin figures are the principal substantive cruxes, now fixed per the researcher's reading: opening balance **CCCC** (400); the total grant **Mil** (1,000) florins (lines 1 and 5); the obligation at line 4 **M. DC.** (1,600); and the per-bishop assessment at line 9 **M** (1,000). The figure **M. DC. florins** (1,600) for an obligation tied to a 1,000-florin grant of which 400 remain is internally awkward and may reflect either a distinct prior reckoning with Muntros or a scribal figure that itself warrants checking against the register. The HTR comparator was internally inconsistent on every numeral except the CCCC (offering *mil*, *M. DC.*, and *m. cl.* in turn), and should not be relied on here. Flagged.

5. *àpoca* (Lat. *apocha*) — a formal written receipt acknowledging payment; its issuance discharges the payer. The reciprocal structure here is standard: the bearer issues the *àpoca* and returns the underlying *obligació* upon collection, closing the instrument.

6. *cascun dels altres bisbes de nostra senyoria*. This clause is the document's substantive crux and was the site of the most consequential HTR error: the HTR comparator read *cascun dels altres lliures de nostra tresoreria* ("each of the other books/entries of our treasury"), which would recast the document as an internal accounting note. The salutation (*Honrat pare en Jesuchristu*) and the logic of the whole letter make **bisbes / senyoria** decisively correct: the letter is one of a set sent to the prelates of the Crown, each assessed a comparable sum. This places the document directly within the king's practice of soliciting "grants" (effectively a fiscal levy) from the

episcopate of his lordship — directly relevant to the dissertation's argument on royal jurisdictional and fiscal reach over the Church.

7. Dating clause now fixed: *a VII dies de juny, l'any de M CCC LXXX VII* = **7 June 1387**, within the first half-year of Joan I's reign (acc. January 1387). *Juny* (June) reading confirmed by the researcher over the earlier *jurjol/juliol* (July) possibility.

8. *Francesch ça Cost[a]*, identified here as the *iussio*/subscription. Francesc ça Costa served in Joan I's chancery (vice-chancellor); his appearance is consistent with the 1387 dating and provides an internal control on the document's authenticity and provenance. The final letters of the surname are abbreviated in the image; *ça Costa* is the expected resolution.

Unresolved Ambiguities (for archival follow-up)

1. **Archival identity.** The register and folio numbers are not legible in the supplied image; cited as f. 121r. Confirm the ACA Cancillería register number and folio.
2. **Addressee.** The bishop addressed is not named in the legible text. Determine whether the register supplies the name (and the see), or whether this is a circular-letter template with the addressee entered per exemplar. Identification would allow the levy to be situated diocesally.
3. **The 1,600-florin obligation (line 4, *M. DC. florins*).** The relationship between this figure and the 1,000-florin grant of which 400 remain outstanding is not internally transparent. Verify the figure against the manuscript and reconstruct the accounting with Johan de Muntros.
4. **Prosopography of Johan de Muntros and Jacme Sala.** Identify both men — Muntros as the party already paid against the obligation, and Sala as the king's bearer/procurator. Check Barcelonese notarial and council records and chancery prosopography for Joan I's reign.
5. **L2 circumstantial phrase (note 1) and the verb *provehir/supplicar* (note 2).** Both resist confident resolution from the image; verify against the register at higher resolution.
6. **Scope of the episcopal levy (note 6).** This letter implies a coordinated assessment of *all* the bishops of the Crown at 1,000 florins each. Determine whether parallel letters to other named prelates survive in the same register sequence — directly pertinent to the dissertation's treatment of royal fiscal reach over the Church.